

MyDAW Operation Manual

From your first recording to editing, mixing and exporting

Version 1.5

MyDAW is Mac software (a DAW) for recording sound from a microphone or audio interface and for playing back, editing and mixing many tracks together.

This manual follows the order in which you actually work, so that even first-time DAW users will not get lost. Start by reading chapters 2 to 5 in order while you record your first song.

Contents

1. What you can do with MyDAW
2. Getting ready
3. The main window
4. Your first recording
5. Playback and basic controls
6. Editing clips
7. Punch-in recording and layered takes
8. Recording through effects (input monitoring)
9. Using the mixer
10. Effects (plug-ins) and FX channels
11. Tempo, click and ruler
12. Adjusting the view
13. Saving, opening and moving projects
14. Importing WAV files and exporting
15. Audio settings
16. Keyboard shortcuts
17. Troubleshooting
18. Glossary

1. What you can do with MyDAW

- **Record** in mono or stereo on as many tracks as you like, at 24-bit and 44.1 or 48 kHz.
- **Overdub**: record a new track while listening to tracks you have already recorded.
- **Punch in**: re-record just the part that went wrong. The joins are smoothed automatically.
- **Edit** recordings (clips): move, trim, split, duplicate, change volume, fade. Everything can be undone.
- **Mix** with faders, pan, mute, solo and meters.
- **Use effects**: Audio Unit (AU) and VST3 plug-ins such as compressors, EQs, reverbs and amp simulators.
- **Export** the finished mix as one WAV file.

2. Getting ready

What you need

- A Mac with Apple Silicon (macOS 13 or later)
- A microphone or an audio interface (the Mac's built-in microphone also works)
- Headphones (if you use speakers while recording, the microphone picks them up)

Start MyDAW and choose a project

- 1 Double-click `MyDAW.app`.
- 2 On the start screen choose **New Project** or **Open Project** (to continue earlier work).
- 3 For **New Project**, choose (or create) a folder for the project. MyDAW creates a `.mydaw` file with the folder's name and a `Recordings` folder for your audio inside it.
- 4 For **Open Project**, choose the folder of an existing project.

First launch only When macOS asks whether “MyDAW” may access the microphone, choose **Allow**. Without it you cannot record.

Plug-in scan Right after launch, a log shows MyDAW looking for installed plug-ins. From the second launch on this takes almost no time.

One-time setup

Click the gear button  at the top and select your equipment (details in chapter 15).

- 1 Choose your audio interface for **Input device** and **Output device**.
- 2 Set **Buffer size** to **256** to start with.
- 3 Click **Apply**.

3. The main window

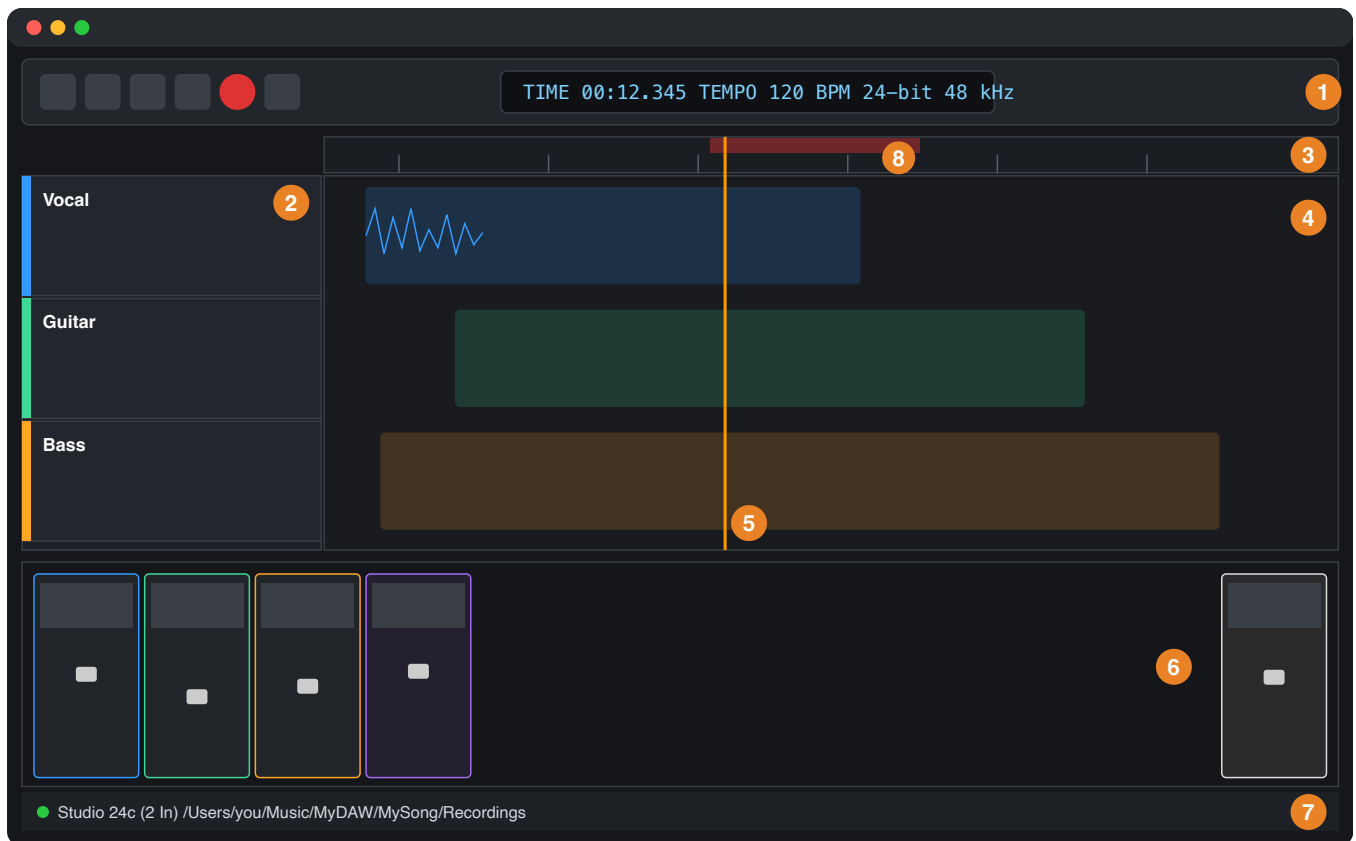


Figure 3-1 Layout of the main window

1	Transport bar: buttons for play, record, save and so on, plus time and tempo displays.
2	Track headers: track name, record arm, mute/solo, input selection and more.
3	Ruler: time (or bars and beats). Click it to move the playback position there.
4	Track lanes: where your recordings (clips) appear as waveforms.
5	Playhead (orange line): the current playback / recording position.
6	Mixer: volume, pan and effects for every track. Drag its top edge to change its height.
7	Status bar: the audio device in use and where recordings are saved.
8	Punch range: the part re-recorded with punch-in (chapter 7).

Transport bar

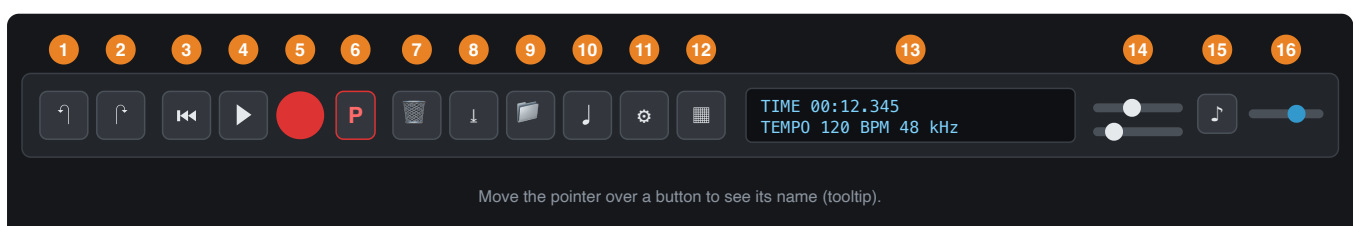


Figure 3-2 Transport bar (hover over a button to see its name)

No.	Button	What it does
1	Undo	Undoes the last clip edit (⌘Z).
2	Redo	Redoes an undone edit (⇧⌘Z).
3	Rewind	Returns to the start, 00:00.000 (⏮).
4	Play / Pause	Starts and stops playback (Space). This button does not record.
5	Record (red circle)	Starts recording on record-armed (R) tracks.
6	P	Turns punch in/out on (chapter 7).
7	Delete	Deletes the selected clip (Delete).
8	Save	Saves the project (⌘S).
9	Open	Opens a project (⌘O).
10	Metronome	Click on/off (change it while stopped).
11	Settings	Opens the audio settings (chapter 15).
12	Snap	Makes clip moves and trims snap to beats.
13	Displays	TIME (position), TEMPO (type the BPM), recording format, storage mode.
14	View scaling	Horizontal zoom, track height, waveform height (chapter 12).
15	Ruler mode	Switches the ruler between time and bars/beats.
16	Master volume	Overall output volume.

Track header

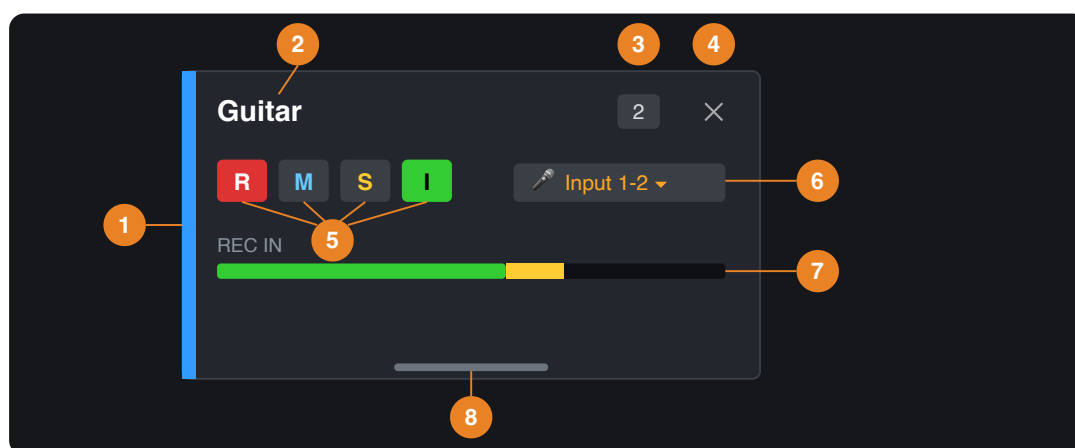


Figure 3-3 Track header

1	Colour bar: click to open a colour palette and change the track colour; “Custom...” lets you pick any colour.
2	Track name: double-click to rename.
3	1 / 2: mono (1) or stereo (2). Cannot be changed once the track contains recordings.
4	X: deletes the track.
5	R record arm, M mute, S solo (hear only this track), I input monitoring (chapter 8).
6	Input channel: the audio interface input used for recording.
7	Meter: input level while armed, output level otherwise.
8	Height: drag the bottom edge to change the track height.

To add a track, click the **+** (**Add Track**) button above the track headers.

4. Your first recording

Here you record one track and listen back to it.

- 1 **Choose a track:** click its **R** button so it turns red (armed).
- 2 **Choose the input:** in the input channel menu (figure 3-3, item 6) pick the input your microphone or guitar is connected to. For a single voice or guitar, set the track to **1** (mono).
- 3 **Check the level:** play and watch the meter. The loudest parts should reach about the yellow area. If it reaches red, turn down the input gain on your audio interface.
- 4 **Choose where to start:** click the ruler, or press **←** to start from the beginning.
- 5 **Record:** click the red **Record** button and perform. The waveform is drawn as you go.
- 6 **Stop:** press **Space**. The recording becomes a clip.
- 7 **Listen back:** turn off **R**, press **←**, then **Space**.

Recording along with a backing After the first track, add a new track, arm it and record in the same way. You will hear the first track while recording the second. While recording, older clips on the track being recorded are silenced.

Recording in time Type the BPM into TEMPO and turn on the metronome before recording to play along with a click (chapter 11).

Recording files Recordings are saved as WAV files in the Recordings folder. The file name contains the track name, channel count and sample rate.

5. Playback and basic controls

To...	Do this
Play / stop	 or the Play button
Go back to the start	 or the Rewind button
Jump to a position	Click the ruler (also while playing)
Hear only some tracks	 (solo) on those tracks
Silence some tracks	 (mute) on those tracks

When the playhead reaches the right edge during playback, the view scrolls on automatically. When stopped, use the scroll bar below the lanes to move around freely.

6. Editing clips

One recording is called a **clip**. Editing never changes the original recording file (non-destructive editing), so feel free to experiment.

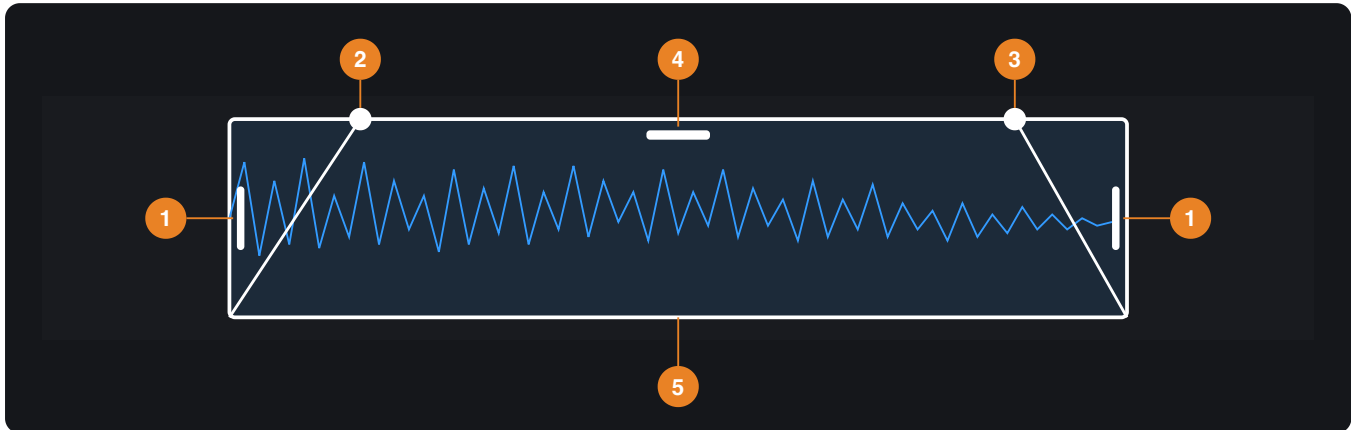


Figure 6-1 Clip handles

1	Left / right edges (trim): drag to shorten or lengthen the audible part.
2	Fade in: drag the white dot at the top left to the right so the sound starts gradually.
3	Fade out: drag the white dot at the top right to the left so the sound ends gradually.
4	Gain: drag the bar at the top centre up or down to change the clip volume (± 24 dB).
5	Body: click to select (thick white frame), drag to move — also onto another track.

Right-click menu

- **Split at Cursor:** splits the clip in two at the playhead.
- **Duplicate Recording:** places a copy right after it.
- **Mute / Unmute Recording:** silences just this clip.
- **Delete Recording:** deletes it.
- **Choose Recording File...:** picks the file again if it cannot be found.

Snap

With Snap on (figure 3-2, item 12), moves and trims snap to whole beats. Turn it off for fine positioning.

Undo and redo

Moves, trims, fades, gain, delete, split and duplicate can be undone with **⌘Z** and redone with **⇧⌘Z** (while stopped).

7. Punch-in recording and layered takes

Use this when a take is almost perfect except for a few bars: re-record only that part.

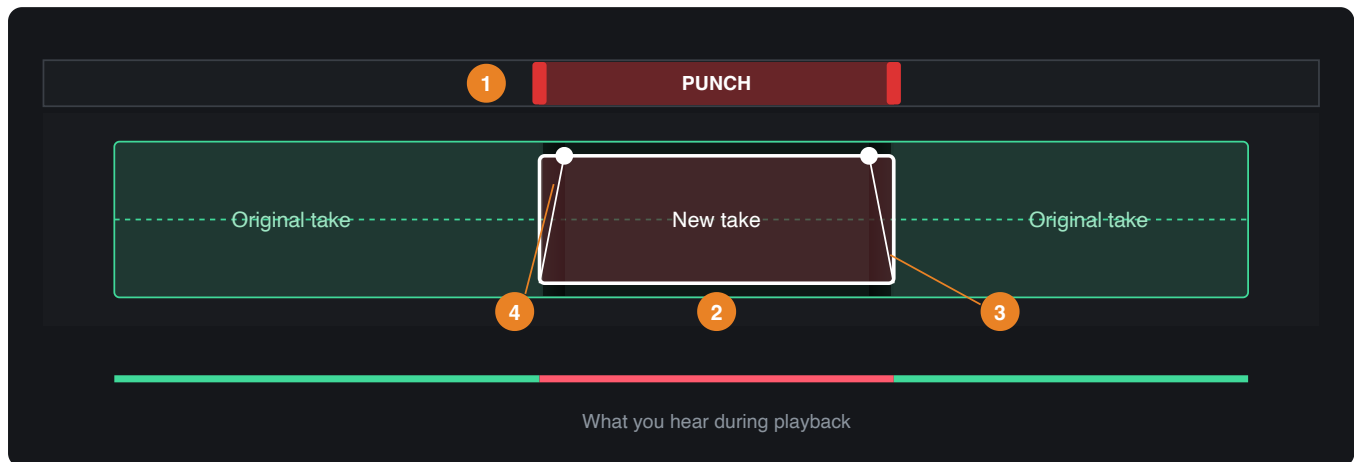


Figure 7-1 Punch range and the re-recorded part on top

- 1 Drag the red handles of the **punch range** on the ruler (figure 7-1, item 1) to the part you want to redo (they move in beats).
- 2 Click **P** in the transport bar to enable punch in/out (the range turns red).
- 3 Turn on **R** on the track to redo.
- 4 Click Record a little before the range and perform. Only what falls inside the range is used.
- 5 When you stop, the new part appears as a new clip (item 2) on top of the original clip.

How overlapping clips play

- Where clips overlap, **only the clip recorded later (the upper clip) plays**. The hidden part of the original clip is shown darker.
- The joins automatically get a **crossfade** (item 3), so there are no gaps or clicks. The default length is 10 ms.
- Moving the fade handles of the upper clip (item 4) changes the crossfade length; the lower clip automatically gets the opposite fade. The lower clip's fade on the overlapped side cannot be edited.
- If you move or delete the upper clip, the lower clip automatically plays normally again.

Fine-tuning the range The whole pass is saved, including audio outside the range. Drag the edges of the upper clip to extend the re-recorded part.

This rule applies to every overlap Not only punch takes: whenever clips overlap after moving or duplicating, the clip added last wins.

8. Recording through effects (input monitoring)

Use this, for example, to hear your guitar through an amp simulator while recording.

- 1 Insert the effect you want (e.g. an amp simulator) on the track (chapter 10).
- 2 Turn on **R** and **I** on the track. When I is filled green you hear the input through the effects (also while stopped).
- 3 Record with the Record button as usual.

The dry signal is recorded The file contains the sound before the effects, so you can change the amp settings later.

If you hear a delay Set **Buffer size** to 128 or 256. If your audio interface's direct monitoring is on, you will hear the dry and processed sound doubled — turn direct monitoring down for that input.

Feedback With a microphone and speakers you may get feedback (a loud squeal). Use headphones.

9. Using the mixer

The mixer at the bottom sets each track's level, left-right position (pan) and effects. Tracks come first, then FX channels, with MASTER (the overall output) at the right.

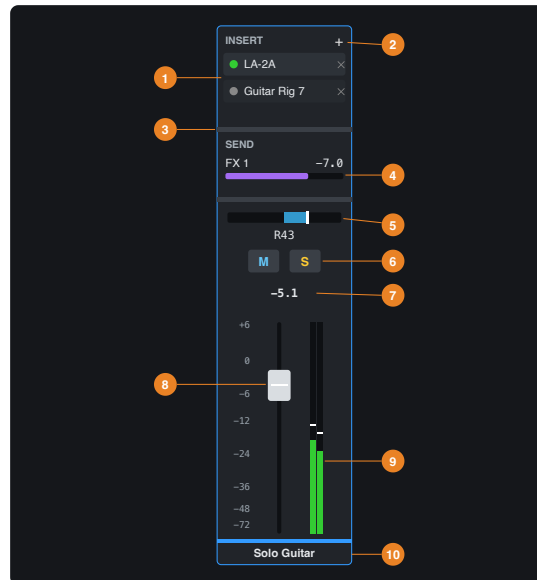


Figure 9-1 One mixer channel (strip)

1	INSERT (plug-in list): green dot turns a plug-in on/off, click the name to open its window, drag to reorder, X removes it.
2	+ : adds a plug-in.
3	Section divider: drag up or down to change the height of the INSERT, SEND and control sections (all channels together).
4	SEND: how much goes to an FX channel. Drag sideways, or double-click the value to type it.
5	Pan: drag sideways to place the sound left or right. <C> is centre, L56 left, R75 right.
6	M / S: mute and solo.
7	Level value: current fader value in dB. Double-click to type (e.g. -6, -inf).
8	Fader: drag up or down to change the level. 0 dB is the reference; you can go up to +6 dB.
9	Meters (L / R): level of each side. Green → yellow (from -12 dB) → red (from -6 dB). The white line shows the recent peak.
10	Name: click to select the track. Double-click an FX channel's name to rename it.

Handy actions

- -click: resets faders and sends to 0 dB and pan to centre.
- -drag: fine adjustment.
- Drag the mixer's top edge: changes the height of the whole mixer.

- Right-click in the mixer: **Add FX** adds an FX channel.

Level tip Adjust the track faders so the MASTER meter does not reach red. If the mix is too loud, lower the tracks rather than MASTER.

10. Effects (plug-ins) and FX channels

Inserting an effect

- 1 Stop playback (plug-ins cannot be inserted while playing).
- 2 Click  in the channel's INSERT section and choose a plug-in.
- 3 Click the plug-in's name to open its window.

Sound passes through the plug-ins from top to bottom. Drag the names to change the order. Plug-ins on MASTER's **POST** section affect the whole song (a limiter, for example).

Supported formats Audio Unit (AU) and VST3 effects. If a product is installed in both formats, only the AU version is listed (using both at once is unstable). Instruments are not supported.

FX channels (sharing a reverb)

Spatial effects such as reverb are usually placed once on an FX channel; each track then decides how much it sends (SEND).

- 1 Click **Add FX** at the top of the mixer (or right-click → Add FX).
- 2 Insert a reverb on the FX channel and set its Mix (dry/wet) to 100% wet.
- 3 Raise the SEND to that FX on each track.

A send carries the track's sound after its effects, fader and pan, so lowering a track's fader also lowers its reverb.

Automatic delay compensation

Some plug-ins need time to process audio (latency). MyDAW reads the latency they report and adjusts playback timing automatically.

11. Tempo, click and ruler

- **Tempo (BPM):** type a number into TEMPO (20–400, default 120).
- **Metronome:** turn it on before playing or recording to hear a click; the first beat of a bar is higher. Switch it while stopped.
- **Ruler:** button 15 in figure 3-2 switches between time and bars/beats.
- **Click timing and volume:** **Click timing offset** (ms) and **Click volume** in the settings.

12. Adjusting the view

Adjustment	How
Horizontal zoom	Magnifier buttons or the timeline slider (20–400 pixels per second)
Height of all tracks	Track height slider (0.5–3×)
Height of one track	Drag the bottom edge of its header
Waveform height	Waveform slider (1–4×; does not change the sound)
Mixer height	Drag the mixer's top edge

13. Saving, opening and moving projects

What a project contains

```
MySong/
├── MySong.mydaw      ← tracks, clip positions, mixer, plug-in settings, ...
└── Recordings/      ← your recorded WAV files
    └── *.wav
```

- **Save:**  or the Save button.
- **Open:**  or the Open button, then choose the project folder.
- **New:** .

Saved with the project: track settings (name, colour, volume, pan, mute, solo, input, R/I), clip positions and edits, mixer and FX, plug-ins and their settings, tempo, metronome, punch range and view settings.

Moving to another Mac Copy (or zip) the **whole project folder**, not just the .mydaw file. Install the plug-ins you use on the other Mac too. Renaming or moving the Recordings folder makes clips impossible to load.

Quitting When you close the window you are asked whether to save (Save / Don't Save / Cancel).

14. Importing WAV files and exporting

Importing a WAV file

- 1 Select the WAV file in Finder.
- 2 Drag it onto a track lane. It is added as a clip at the playhead.

The file is copied into the project's Recordings folder (the original is untouched). Files must be **24-bit WAV** at **the current sample rate**.

Exporting the finished mix

- 1 Stop playback and recording.
- 2 Choose **File** → **Export Master Mix...** and pick where to save.
- 3 Check the start and end times (seconds). The default end covers all clips.
- 4 Click **Export**. Exporting takes as long as playing the song.

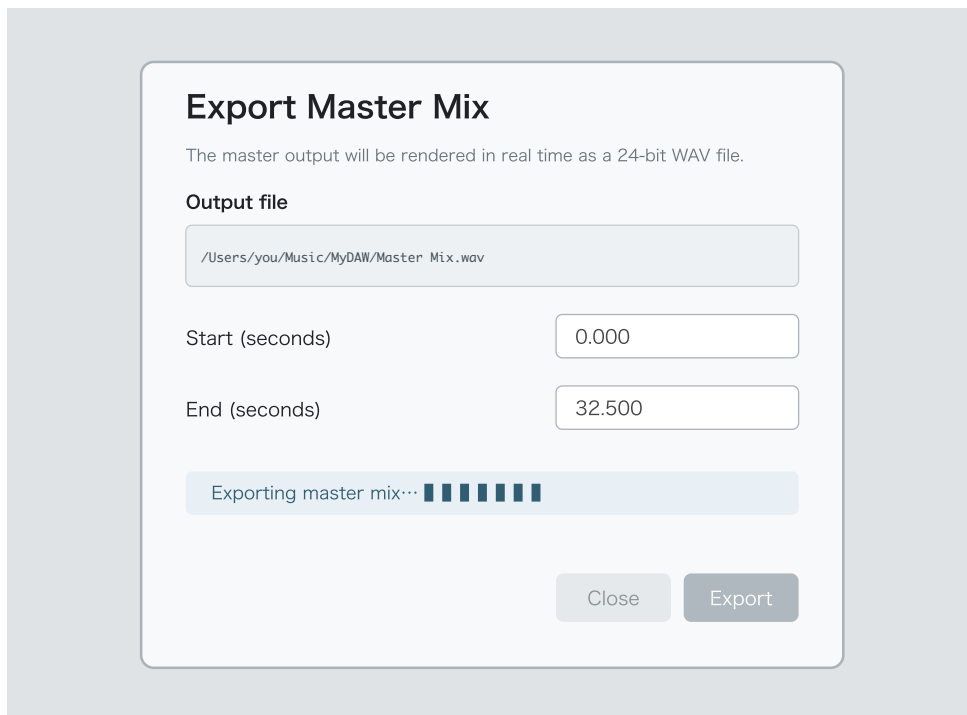


Figure 14-1 Export Master Mix dialog

15. Audio settings

Open with the gear button (not available while playing or recording). Click **Apply** after changing anything.

Audio Buffer Settings
Input and output devices use the same Core Audio buffer size.

- 1 Recordings folder: ../MySong/Recordings
- 2 Input device: Studio 24c ▼
- 3 Output device: Studio 24c ▼
- 4 Sample rate: 48 kHz ▼
- 5 Additional recording compensation: 0.0 ms
- 6 Click timing offset: 0.0 ms
- 7 Click volume: 70%
- 8 Buffer size: 256 frames (5.3 ms) ▼

Cancel Apply

Figure 15-1 Audio settings

1	Recordings folder: where recordings are saved (normally the project's Recordings folder).
2	Input device: the device you record from.
3	Output device: the device you listen through; normally the same audio interface as the input.
4	Sample rate: 44.1 kHz or 48 kHz.
5	Additional recording compensation: manual correction of recording position (ms). Positive values move recordings earlier. Normally leave at 0.
6	Click timing offset: shifts when the click sounds (-500 to +500 ms).
7	Click volume: loudness of the click.
8	Buffer size: smaller means less delay, larger means more stability. Use 128–256 for recording and input monitoring, 512–1024 for mixing.

After changing the sample rate If you change it with a project open, re-insert your VST3 plug-ins.

16. Keyboard shortcuts

Key	Action
Space	Play / stop
←	Go to the start
Delete	Delete the selected clip
⌘Z	Undo
⇧⌘Z / ⌘Y	Redo
⌘S	Save
⌘O	Open
⌘N	New project
⌘-click (mixer)	Fader / send to 0 dB, pan to centre
⌘-drag (mixer)	Fine adjustment
Double-click (values, names)	Type a value / rename

17. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to check
Cannot record / meter does not move	Microphone permission (System Settings → Privacy & Security → Microphone), Input device, the track's R button, the input channel.
No sound	Output device, MASTER and track faders, M (mute) / S (solo), speaker or headphone volume.
Play does not record	Recording uses the red Record button; Play only plays.
Recordings are out of time	Check the buffer size, record the same sound again to measure the offset, and correct it with Additional recording compensation.
Effect input sounds late	Buffer size 128–256; turn down the interface's direct monitoring.
A plug-in is missing from the list	Make sure it is an effect (not an instrument). Products with an AU version are listed as AU only.
Cannot add a plug-in	Stop playback first.
Cannot import a WAV	It must be 24-bit and at the current sample rate.
A clip says its file cannot be found	Right-click → Choose Recording File... and pick the WAV again.

18. Glossary

Term	Meaning
DAW	Digital Audio Workstation — software for recording, editing and mixing.
Track	A lane that records and plays one instrument or part.
Clip	One recorded piece of audio that you can move and edit.
Record arm	Making a track ready to record with its R button.
Punch in/out	Re-recording only a chosen range.
Crossfade	Joining two sounds by fading one out while fading the other in.
Fader	The control that sets volume.
Pan	Where the sound appears between left and right.
dB (decibel)	Unit of level. 0 dB is the reference; -6 dB is roughly half as loud.
Mute / solo	Silence a track / hear only that track.
Plug-in (effect)	Add-on software that processes sound; formats AU and VST3.
INSERT	Effects placed directly on a channel; sound passes through them top to bottom.
SEND / FX channel	Sending part of a track's sound to a shared effect (the FX channel).
MASTER	The final output where all tracks are combined.
Buffer size	The block size audio is processed in. Smaller means less delay but more CPU load.
Sample rate	How many times per second sound is measured (44.1 / 48 kHz).
Input monitoring	Listening to the incoming sound through the track's effects.